A Borrowed Recovery?

The 2025 Teacher-Workforce Data for the United States

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In brief. Five turbulent years after the pandemic first hit American classrooms, the 2025 workforce data read almost calm. Almost.

- Teacher attrition has come back to earth. In 2024–25, 7.9 per cent of public-school teachers left education — in line with the pre-pandemic norm of 7.7 per cent, and down from 10.4 per cent at the height of the disruption.
- Leaving the *classroom* has not normalised: 13.3 per cent of teachers left it, still two points above the old norm, and a record two in five of them moved to other education work rather than out of the sector. Schools are keeping their people and losing their teachers.
- The workforce shrank in 2025 — by about 3.7 per cent — even as enrolment continued the slide that began in 2019. The inflow that remains is grey: the median new entrant is 42 years old, three quarters arrive from another job, and fewer than one in five is under 30.
- Real teacher pay is 5.6 per cent below its 2010 level and has slipped from 87 to 79 cents per dollar earned by the median graduate.
- Retention today is exactly where a cold labour market would put it. Nothing underneath it — not pay, not the pipeline — has been repaired. The recovery is real, but it is borrowed from the business cycle, and the cycle always asks for its money back.

1. Fewer pupils — and now fewer teachers

American public schools have been losing pupils since autumn 2019: enrolment peaked at 50.8 million and has since given up 1.4 million students, with further declines projected as smaller birth cohorts reach school age. For five years the teaching workforce ignored the demography. It dipped in 2021, recovered, and by 2024 hovered near its 2019 peak of 4.6 million, so pupil–teacher ratios quietly improved (Figure 1).

In 2025 the workforce stopped ignoring it. The stock of qualified teachers fell from 4.54 to 4.37 million — 3.7 per cent, the sharpest one-year drop in the series outside the pandemic itself. Some of this is

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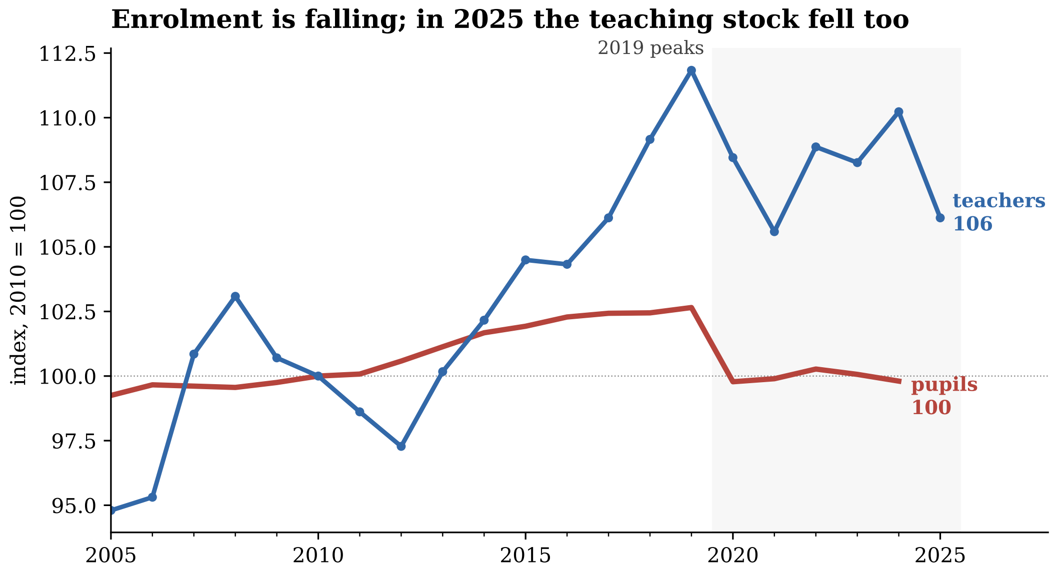

Figure 1: Public-school pupils and full-time qualified teachers, indexed to 2010.

Teachers: CPS monthly data, employed K–12 teachers (occupations 2310–2330) with at least a bachelor's degree, annual average of weighted monthly stocks; survey estimates carry sampling error of roughly ±1–2 per cent. The 2025 average covers eleven months — no CPS was collected in October 2025 during the federal shutdown — but the like-for-like eleven-month 2024 figure (4.52M) confirms the decline. Pupils: NCES, Digest of Education Statistics, table 203.10, fall enrolment in public schools.

schools finally adjusting to smaller cohorts and the end of federal relief money; districts that staffed up on ESSER funds are letting attrition do the shrinking. But the composition of the change matters, because the outflow is not being matched by a young inflow — a point Section 3 returns to.

2. Attrition is back to normal — with an asterisk

The headline number of the 2025 data is a good one. Of the teachers in public-school classrooms in 2024, 7.9 per cent had left education entirely a year later: not teaching, not working in a school, college or any education-adjacent job. That is statistically indistinguishable from the 2005–18 average of 7.7 per cent, and far below the 10.4 per cent reached when the pandemic and the reopening chaos emptied classrooms (Figure 2). By age, the picture is uniformly calmer: attrition among teachers under 35, which spiked hardest after 2020, is back near its own long-run norm, as is the mid-career trough and the retirement-driven rate of the over-50s (Figure 3).

The asterisk is the dashed line above it. Counting exits from the *classroom* rather than from education, attrition in 2024–25 was 13.3 per cent — still roughly two points above its pre-pandemic norm, and rising while the blue line fell. The wedge between the two lines, teachers who stay in education but stop teaching, reached 5.3 percentage points, the widest in twenty years of data; before the pandemic it averaged 3.4. Two in five of last year's classroom leavers, in other words, did not leave the sector: they became instructional coaches, administrators, counselors, tutors, college instructors. For school budgets this is churn; for pupils it is the same empty desk at the front of the room. The post-pandemic exodus from education is over, but an internal migration out of the classroom has replaced it — and it does not show up in the headline rate.

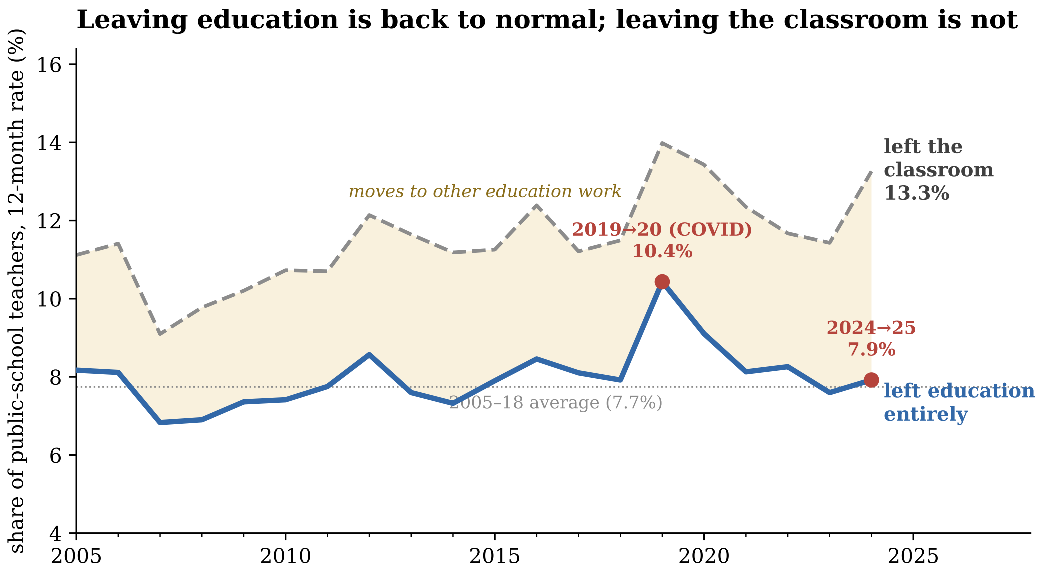

Figure 2: Two ways to leave: out of the classroom, and out of education.

Public-school full-time K–12 teachers (BA+) followed twelve months in linked CPS interviews, 2005–2024 base years (n = 91,035; 2,841 in 2024, which lacks October links because no October 2025 survey exists). Blue: no longer working in any education occupation at t+12 nor teaching at any later interview. Dashed: no longer a classroom teacher by the same standard. The gap between the lines is movement into other education work — support roles, administration, post-secondary and other instruction.

3. The inflow is running on career-changers

Attrition is only half of the ledger. The other half — who replaces the leavers — is where the 2025 data look least like a recovery. The median teacher who entered a classroom between 2024 and 2025 was *42 years old*. Three quarters came directly from another job, a further 18 per cent from outside the labour force, and fewer than one in five was under 30. Teaching in America is increasingly staffed at the margin by mid-career adults — returners circling back and professionals switching in — rather than by a pipeline of the young: the under-35 share of the teaching stock has drifted down from about 32 per cent in the mid-2000s to 29 per cent today, and one leaver in six is back in a classroom within months, a revolving door that papers over the thinness of genuinely new supply.

Career-changers are not worse teachers, and a workforce that can draw on them is more resilient than one that cannot. But an inflow with a median age of 42 buys fewer future teaching years per hire, arrives needing certification flexibility the current systems ration, and — crucially — responds to relative pay, which is the one margin that has moved in the wrong direction for fifteen years.

4. Pay never came back

Adjusted for inflation, the median full-time teacher earned $1,380 a week in 2025 against $1,462 in 2010 — 5.6 per cent less (Figure 4). Over the same fifteen years the median wage of all workers rose 9 per cent in real terms, and that of degree-holders rose 3 per cent. Relative to the graduate labour market in which teachers are actually recruited, teacher pay has slid from 87 to 79 cents on the dollar. The inflation surge did the sharpest damage: between 2021 and 2023 teachers lost nearly 6 per cent of their real weekly pay, and the partial rebound since has recovered less than half of it.

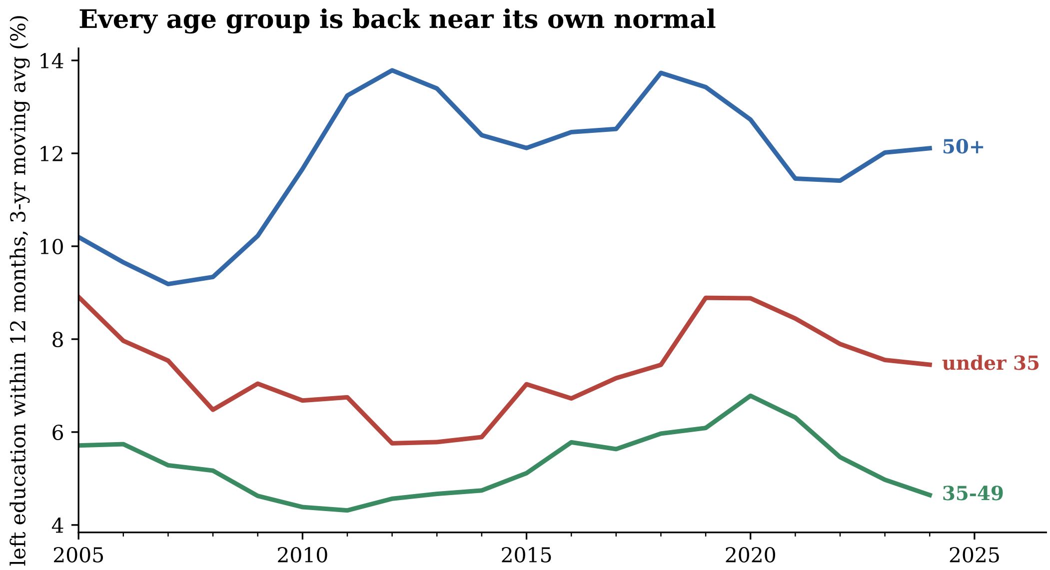

Figure 3: Attrition from education by age of teacher.

Same universe and definition as the blue line of Figure 2, split by age at the base interview; three-year centred moving averages. The 50+ line embeds retirements and is structurally the highest.

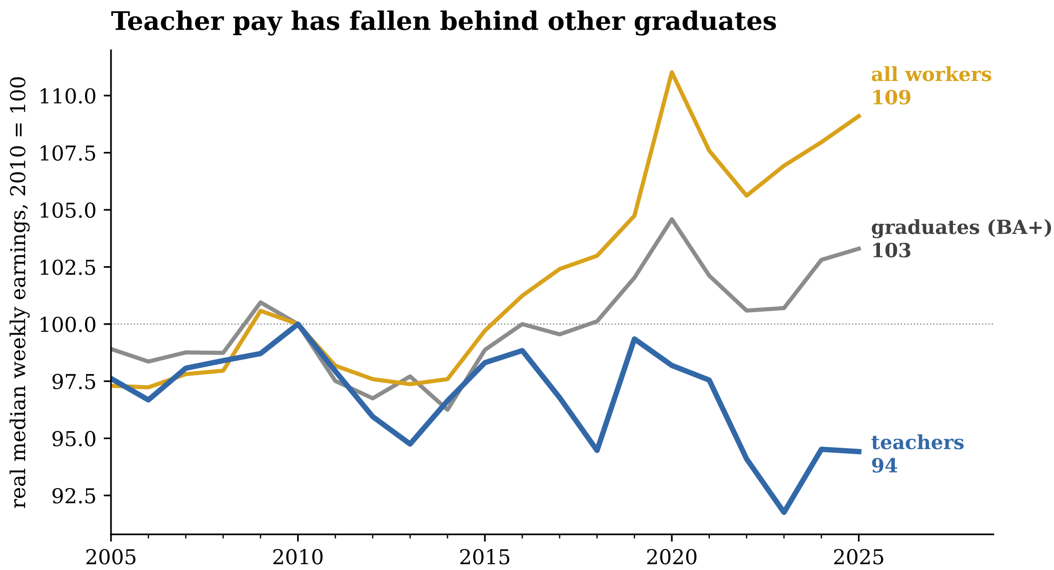

Figure 4: Real median weekly earnings: teachers, all graduates, all workers.

Teachers: weighted median usual weekly earnings of full-time K–12 teachers (BA+), CPS outgoing-rotation interviews, deflated by CPI-U. Graduates: BLS median usual weekly earnings, bachelor's degree and higher, age 25+. All workers: BLS real median usual weekly earnings, age 16+. Indexed to 2010 = 100.

A pay position like this coexists with normal attrition for one reason only: the alternatives on offer. Which brings the story to its least comfortable chart.

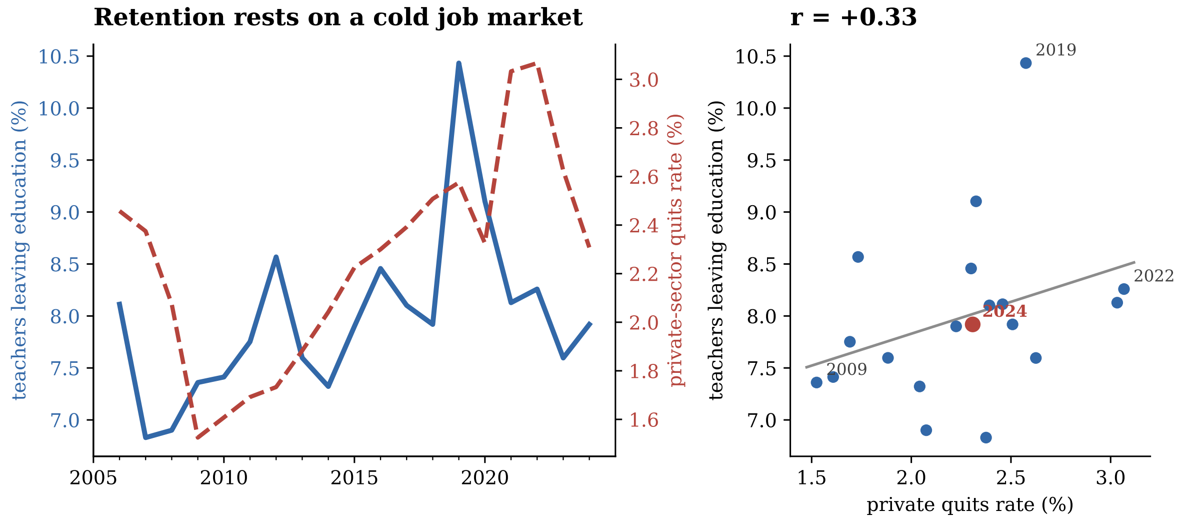

Figure 5: Teacher attrition and the outside labour market.

Left: teachers leaving education (as in Figure 2) and the private-sector quits rate (JOLTS, annual average of monthly rates). Right: the same two series as a scatter with an OLS fit; the 2024 point lies on the line. The 2019 observation links into 2020 and carries the COVID shock.

5. A recovery on loan

Teacher retention in the United States moves with the temperature of the labour market around it. Across two decades, the rate at which teachers leave education tracks the private-sector quits rate — the economy's willingness to change jobs — with a correlation of +0.33; teachers stay put when everyone stays put (Figure 5). And the market has cooled sharply: private quits have fallen from 3.1 per cent a month at the 2022 frenzy to 2.3 per cent, hiring rates are at post-2014 lows, and job openings per unemployed worker are back below their pre-pandemic level.

At a 2.3 per cent quits rate, the historical relationship predicts teacher attrition of almost exactly 8 per cent. Observed attrition: 7.9. The 2024 point sits precisely on the fitted line (Figure 5, right panel). Today's normal attrition, in other words, is not evidence that teaching has become more attractive — pay says the opposite — but evidence that its competitors have become less so. It is retention borrowed from a slack market, on terms set by the next expansion: the same relationship implies that a return of quits to their 2022 level would push attrition back up by half a point, before counting the classroom-exit wedge and the grey inflow that a hot market would also amplify.

6. What this means

Read quickly, the 2025 data close the book on the pandemic teacher crisis: attrition normal, every age group settled, ratios improving. Read carefully, they describe a workforce in remission, not in health. The stock is now falling. The classroom is leaking into the back office at a record rate. New supply is old, and thin among the young. Pay is eight points further behind the graduate market than in 2010. And the retention that looks so reassuring is fully explained by the coldest hiring market in a decade.

None of those five facts is controlled by school systems' good luck holding. One is: pay. The quiet years the labour market has lent are precisely the window in which restoring teacher pay — and making the classroom itself a job people want to keep, not a stepping stone to the jobs around it — is cheapest, because retention does not need rescuing at the same time. The data will say whether the window was used. On the 2025 vintage, it is still open, and still closing.

Data and definitions. Teacher series: CPS basic monthly microdata, January 2005–December 2025 (Census Bureau; NBER mirror before 2021). The CPS re-interviews each address twelve months apart; persons are linked across interviews and validated on sex, race and age progression (Madrian–Lefgren). Attrition (Figures 2, 3, 5): public-school full-time K–12 teachers — occupations 2310 (elementary/middle), 2320 (secondary), 2330 (special education) — with a bachelor's degree or higher, base rotations with re-interviews; a leaver has left the classroom (dashed) or all education-adjacent occupations (solid) at $t+12$ and is not observed teaching in any later interview. This definition matches the NCES Teacher Follow-up Survey and retrospective-CPS benchmarks (public-school leaver rates of 7.6–8.0 per cent). Stocks and earnings use the full K–12 universe including private schools. All estimates use final person weights. External series: NCES Digest table 203.10 (enrolment); BLS via FRED — LEU0252918500, LEU0252881600 (comparator earnings), JTS1000QUR (quits), CPIAUCSL (deflator). No CPS was collected in October 2025 (federal shutdown): 2025 stocks average eleven months and the 2024→25 links exclude October. Replication code: `src/30_borrowed_recovery_data.py` and `src/31_borrowed_recovery_figures.py`.

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